

125 Peter

The fisherman who fell hard, was restored, and became a rock for the early church.

Simon was a Galilean fisherman when his brother Andrew brought him to Jesus, who named him Cephas, or Peter, "a stone." Peter speaks first, acts fast, and sometimes gets it badly wrong. He confessed Jesus as the Christ, then tried to talk him out of the cross. He promised to die with him, then denied him three times. Yet the risen Jesus restored him, and in Acts Peter preaches at Pentecost, heals in Jesus' name, and opens the gospel to the Gentiles. Two New Testament letters bear his name.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Simon; Cephas (Aramaic), Peter (Greek), "a stone" (John 1:42)
<i>Family</i>	Son of Jonas; brother of Andrew; married (Mark 1:30)
<i>Home</i>	Bethsaida; later Capernaum (John 1:44; Mark 1:21, 29)
<i>Work</i>	Fisherman, partner of James and John (Luke 5:10)
<i>When</i>	With Jesus c. AD 28–30; leader in Jerusalem into the AD 40s
<i>Key people</i>	Andrew, James, John, Cornelius, Paul
<i>Main passages</i>	Matthew 16; Luke 5; 22; John 21; Acts 1–15; 1–2 Peter
<i>Death</i>	Not in Scripture; tradition says Rome, c. AD 64–67

"And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God."

Matthew 16:16, KJV

The life of Peter

Dates approximate (AD); this study dates the crucifixion c. AD 30 (some prefer AD 33).

c. AD 27–28 <i>By the Jordan</i>	● Meets Jesus Andrew brings his brother Simon to Jesus, who names him Cephas, a stone. <i>John 1:40–42</i>
c. AD 28 <i>Sea of Galilee</i>	● Leaves his nets After a net-breaking catch at Jesus' word, he leaves everything to follow him. <i>Luke 5:1–11</i>
c. AD 29 <i>Caesarea Philippi</i>	● Confesses the Christ Peter calls Jesus the Christ, then rebukes him for speaking of the cross. <i>Matthew 16:13–23</i>
c. AD 30 <i>The high priest's courtyard</i>	● Denies Jesus Peter three times denies knowing him, then goes out and weeps bitterly. <i>Luke 22:31–34, 54–62</i>
c. AD 30 <i>By the sea</i>	● Restored by the risen Lord Three times Jesus asks, "Lovest thou me?" and charges him to feed his flock. <i>John 21:1–19</i>
c. AD 30 <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Preaches at Pentecost Filled with the Spirit, he preaches Christ; about three thousand are baptized. <i>Acts 2:1–41</i>
AD 44 <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Freed from prison After Herod Agrippa I kills James, an angel leads the jailed Peter out. <i>Acts 12:1–17</i>
c. AD 49 <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Speaks at the council Peter says God saves Gentiles and Jews alike by grace. <i>Acts 15:6–11</i>

Group notes

Key activities

After Acts 15 Peter drops out of the narrative; Scripture does not record his later travels or death.

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- 1 Left his nets.** "Depart from me; for I am a sinful man, O Lord." *Luke 5:4-11*

 - 2 Walked on the water.** Sinking in the wind, he cried, "Lord, save me." *Matthew 14:28-31*

 - 3 Spoke for the Twelve.** "Lord, to whom shall we go? thou hast the words of eternal life." *John 6:66-69*

 - 4 Confessed and then stumbled.** He rebuked Jesus for speaking of suffering: "Get thee behind me, Satan." *Matthew 16:16-23*

 - 5 Saw the Transfiguration.** He offered to build three tabernacles, not knowing what to say. *Mark 9:2-8*

 - 6 Drew his sword.** He cut off Malchus's ear, and Jesus told him to put the sword away. *John 18:10-11*

 - 7 Denied his Lord.** Three times in one night he said he did not know Jesus. *Mark 14:66-72*

 - 8 Was restored.** The risen Jesus appeared to him and later gave him a threefold charge to feed his sheep. *Luke 24:34; John 21:15-17*

 - 9 Preached and healed.** At the temple gate he told a lame man, "Silver and gold have I none," and raised him up in Jesus' name. *Acts 3:1-16*

 - 10 Stood before the council.** With the apostles he answered, "We ought to obey God rather than men." *Acts 4:1-20; 5:29*

 - 11 Welcomed Cornelius.** A vision at Joppa taught him that God is no respecter of persons, and he had a Roman centurion's household baptized. *Acts 10:1-48; 11:1-18*

 - 12 Wrote to scattered believers.** The letter of 1 Peter encourages Christians facing suffering to hope and to do good. *1 Peter 1:1-9*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Tradition: martyred in Rome under Nero, c. AD 64–67 (hinted in John 21:18–19); the upside-down cross is a later story.

Old Testament

Joel 2:28–32	Quoted at Pentecost (Acts 2:16–21)
Psalm 16:8–11; 110:1	Preached of Jesus' resurrection (Acts 2:25–35)
Psalm 118:22; Isaiah 28:16	The rejected corner stone (1 Peter 2:6–7)
Echo: Jonah 1:3	Jonah fled Gentiles from Joppa; Peter is sent from there

New Testament

Matthew 16:18	"Upon this rock": Peter, his confession, or Christ? Views differ
1 Corinthians 15:5	The risen Lord "was seen of Cephas"
Galatians 1:18; 2:7–14	Paul visits him, and later rebukes him at Antioch
1 Peter 5:1, 13; 2 Peter 1:16–18	"Babylon" often read as Rome; 2 Peter's authorship debated

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus ask Peter three times by the sea (John 21:15–17)?
2. *Understand:* Why was the cross so hard for Peter to accept?
3. *Apply:* Peter wept but did not stay away. What helps you come back to God after failing?
4. *Apply:* God shows no partiality. Who outside your usual circle could you welcome this week?